

Metaphysics: Paper Topics 1

Due date: Thursday, February 12th.

Length: 5-7 pages.

Each of these paper topics asks you to do two things: to *explain* one of Berkeley's arguments, claims, or strategies, and to *evaluate* or 'critically discuss' it. In the explanatory part of your paper, you should take care to use your own words and structure rather than Berkeley's: often you will have to make explicit various premises and inferences that Berkeley takes for granted. Unless you take the 'exegetical option' (explained below), you should make sure that the evaluative part of your paper contains at least the following: (i) a clearly-explained *objection* to (some aspect of) the argument, claim or strategy of Berkeley's that you have explained, and (ii) a clearly-explained *response* to that objection on behalf of Berkeley.

Notes:

- (i) This doesn't have to be the *whole* of your critical discussion: you might for example go on to suggest a rejoinder to the response, or to present some unrelated objection.
- (ii) An objection to the *conclusion* of an argument isn't an objection to the *argument*: an objection to an argument must attempt to explain where the argument goes wrong.
- (iii) *The exegetical option* (this is recommended only for advanced students). If you take this option, your evaluative section doesn't have to have the structure described above, and may be quite short. But your *explanatory* section should include a presentation of at least *two* different views about how the claim, argument or strategy in question should be understood, as well as some discussion of the pros and cons of each of these views, of a philosophical (as opposed to, say, lexicographic) nature.
- (iv) The explanatory and evaluative aspects of your paper don't have to be separate, they can be intertwined. But I'd recommend keeping them separate unless you really know what you're doing.
- (v) Please don't waste time summarising the whole book: only mention other parts of the *Dialogues* when they are relevant to the task at hand.
- (vi) Jim Pryor maintains a very useful website called 'Guidelines on Writing a Philosophy Paper', which I recommend you peruse:
<http://www.princeton.edu/~jimpryor/general/writing.html>.

Topics:

1. In the *First Dialogue* Berkeley presents several arguments which are collectively known as 'arguments from variation' (or 'arguments from variability'). Choose one (or if the differences between the arguments are relevant to the evaluative points you want to make, more than one) of these. Explain in your own words what the argument is meant to establish. Then explain how the argument works, in a way that makes

explicit the role played by any non-obvious assumptions that Berkeley takes for granted. Finally, critically discuss the argument.

2. 'Philonous: How say you, Hylas, can you see a thing which is at the same time unseen? Hylas: No, that were a contradiction. Philonous: Is it not as great a contradiction to talk of *conceiving* a thing which is *unconceived*?' (86/200) This is the kernel of Berkeley's so-called 'Master Argument'. Explain what this argument is meant to establish, and how it works. Then critically discuss the argument.
3. 'Hylas: To speak the truth, Philonous, I think there are two kinds of objects, the one perceived immediately, which are likewise called *ideas*; the other are real things or external objects perceived by the mediation of ideas, which are their images and representations.' (89/203) Explain in your own words the view Hylas is articulating in this passage, and explain and evaluate one or more of Berkeley's arguments against this view.
4. In the *Second Dialogue* Berkeley presents several arguments against the existence of matter. Explain and evaluate any one of these arguments. Your explanation should make it clear how your chosen argument relates to the conclusions reached in the *First Dialogue*.
5. Explain and critically discuss Berkeley's strategy for resisting the objection that his metaphysics conflicts with common sense.